The Fourposter

By Jan de Hartog

ACT II, SCENE 1

(AT RISE, there is no one in the room. SHE enters door Center and slams the door behind her. SHE stands at - the foot of the bed, removing her evening gloves. Crosses up Right to dressing table, throws gloves on the table, crosses Left Center and is stopped by a KNOCK at the door. SHE stands Left Center for a moment. The KNOCK is repeated, more insistently.)

SHE: *(After a pause.)* Come in.

HE: *(Enters, closes door.)* Excuse me. *(Goes to the dressing room Left, gets his night clothes, re-enters and crosses to door up Center.)* Good night.

SHE: *(As HE opens door.)* You were the life and soul of the party this evening, with your interminable little stories.

HE: *(Starts out, stops, turns.)* My dear, if you don't enjoy playing second fiddle, I suggest you either quit the orchestra or form one of your own. *(Goes out and shuts door.)*

SHE: *(Mutters after a moment's stupefaction.)* Now, I've had enough! *(Runs to door, rips it open, stands in hallway and calls off.)* Michael! *(Then bellows.)* Michael! Come here! *(Re-enters, crosses Left Center, takes off evening wrap, throws it on bed.)*

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INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: It is 1901 and Michael and Agnes have been married for eleven years.
ACTOR: They have had a wonderful marriage, but now there are strains, serious strains. They are both feeling unappreciated.
ACTRESS: Michael has finally become a successful author, doted upon by admirers.
ACTOR: And Agnes, who has been his muse and honest critic, is feeling pushed aside.
TOGETHER: The Fourposter by Jan de Hartog

HE: *(Pops in. At up Center. Has top hat and cane in hand and evening cape over arm.)* Have you taken leave of your senses? The servants?

SHE: *(At Left Center.)* I don't care if the whole town hears it. *(HE exits)* Come back, I say!

HE: *(Re-enters.)* All right. This situation is no longer bearable! *(Closes door.)*

SHE: What on earth is the matter with you?

HE: Now, let me tell you one thing, calmly. *(SHE crosses below him to dressing table up Right. Takes off plume, throws it on table.)* My greatest mistake has been to play up to you, plying you with presents

SHE: I like that! *(Picks up gloves.)*

HE: Calmly! Do you know what I should have done? I should have packed you off to boarding school, big as you are, to learn deportment.

SHE: *(Turns to him.)* Deportment for what?

HE: *(Crossing down Center.)* To be worthy of me.

SHE: The pompous idiot whose book sold three hundred thousand copies!

HE: That is entirely beside the point.

SHE: It is right to the point! *(Carrying gloves.)* Before you had written that cursed novel, the rest of the world helped me to keep you sane. *(HE crosses Left.)* Every time you had finished a book or a play or God knows what, and consid-ered yourself to be the greatest genius since Shakespeare*(HE says, "Now really!" HE puts cape, hat, gloves on wall chair Left.)* -I was frightened to death that it might turn out to be a success. *(SHE crosses to him.)* But, thank Heaven, it turned out to be such a thorough failure every time, that I won the battle with your egolomania. But now, now this book, the only book you ever

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confessed to be trash until you read the papers-oh, what's the use! *(Crosses down Right Center, rolls up gloves.)*

HE: My dear woman, I may be vain, but you are making a tragic mistake. . .

SHE: *(Crossing up Center. Laughs.)* Now listen! *(Laughs.)* Just listen to him! To be married to a man for eleven years, and then to be addressed like a public meeting. *(Throws gloves on dressing table.)* Tragic mistake! *(HE sits Left center. SHE crosses down to him.)* Can't you hear yourself, you poor darling idiot, that you've sold your soul to a sentimental novel?

HE: Agnes, are you going on like this, or must I

SHE: Yes, yes, you must! You shall hear it. *(HE pounds floor with cane.)* And don't interrupt me! There is only one person in this world who loves you in spite of what you are, and let me tell you- *(SHE crosses Center.)*

HE: You are mistaken. There is a person in this world who loves me-because of what I am.

SHE: *(At Center.)* And what are you, my darling?

HE: Ask her.

SHE: Her

HE: Yes.

SHE: Oh- *(Crosses up Center, holds onto bed post.)* Who is she?

HE: You don't know her.

SHE: Is she-young? *(Turns upstage.)* How young?

HE: No. *(Rises. Crossing Left. Picks up clothes.)* I'll be damned if I go on with this. You look like a corpse.

SHE: A corpse?

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HE: *(Crossing up to arch.)* So pale, I mean. *(At door.)* Agnes, I'm not such a monster, that- *(Crossing down Center to her.)* Sit down. Please, Agnes, do sit- Agnes!

SHE: *(Turns away. Crossing down Left.)* No, no-it's nothing. I'm all right. What do you think? That I should faint in my thirty-first year because of something so-so ordinary?

HE: Ordinary?

SHE: With two children? I didn't faint when Robert had the mumps, did I?

HE: *(Crossing down Center.)* Don't you think this is a little different?

SHE: No, Michael. This belongs to the family medicine chest.

HE: I love-her!

SHE: SO, not me anymore? *(HE doesn't reply.)* I don't mean as a friend, or as-as the mother of your children, but as a wife? *(HE crosses down Right.)* You may tell me honestly, really. Is that why you've been sleeping in the study?

HE: *(At window Right.)* I haven't slept a wink.

SHE: *(At Left Center.)* I see. It must be Cook who snores.

HE: *(Turns to her.)* Since when do I snore?

SHE: Not you, dear, Cook. Every night when I went down the passage.

HE: *(Goes to the door, opens it.)* Good night!

SHE: *(At Left Center.)* Sleep well.

HE: *(Crossing down Center.)* What was that?

SHE: Sleep well.

HE: Oh- *(Stops at door, then slams it shut.)* No! *(Throws clothes down on sofa at foot of bed. Down Center.)* I'll be damned, I won't stand it!

SHE: What is the matter?

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HE: Cook snores! Agnes, I love somebody else! It's driving me crazy! You, the children, she, the children, you-for three weeks I have lived through hell, and all you've got to say is "Cook snores!"

SHE: *(Steps toward him.)* But darling

HE: *(Crossing below sofa down Right.)* No, no, no; no! You are so damned sure of yourself that it makes me sick! *(SHE crosses up Center facing bed.)* I know you don't take this seriously, but believe me, I love that woman! I must have that woman or I'll go mad! *(Crosses to above sofa.)*

SHE: *(Turns to him.)* Haven't you-had her yet?

HE: *(Crosses Center to her.)* At last! Thank God, a sign of life. *(SHE sits on sofa at foot of bed.)* Why haven't you looked at me like that before? I have begged, implored, crawled to you for a little understanding and warmth, and love, and got nothing. Even my book, that was written inspired by you, longing for you-right from the beginning you have seen it as a rival. *(Crossing down Left.)* Whatever I did, whatever I tried: a carriage, servants, money, dresses, paintings, everything-you hated that book. And now? *(Crossing up Left.)* Now you have driven me into somebody else's arms. Somebody else, who understands at least one thing clearly: that she will have to share me with my work. *(Above chair down Left.)*

SHE: Does she understand that she will have to share you with other women as well?

HE: She doesn't need to. At last I found a woman who'll live with my work, and a better guarantee of my faithfulness nobody could have. *(Crosses onto dais.)*

SHE: But how does she live with it? What does she do?

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HE: She listens. *(Sits on bed.)* She encourages me-with a look, a touch, a-well, an encouragement. When I cheer, she cheers with me, when I meditate, she meditates with me

SHE: And when you throw crockery, she throws crockery with you?

HE: *(Checks himself.)* Haven't you understood one single word of what I have been saying? Won't you, can't you see that I have changed?

SHE: No.

HE: *(Rises. Crossing up Right Center.)* Then you are blind, blind, blind! That's all I can say. At any rate, you've changed.

SHE: I!

HE: *(Crossing Right to above sofa.)* No, don't let's start that.

SHE: Go on.

HE: No, it's senseless. No reason to torture you any longer, once I have . . .

SHE: Once you have tasted blood?

HE: *(Crossing around sofa.)* Agnes, I'm sorry it was necessary for me to hurt you. It couldn't very well have been done otherwise. I'm at the mercy of a feeling stronger than I. *(Sits sofa.)*

SHE: Rotten, isn't it?

HE: Horrible.

SHE: And yet-at the same time not altogether.

HE: No. On the other hand, it's delicious.

SHE: The greatest thing a human being can experience.

HE: I'm glad you understand it so well.

SHE: Understand?-why, of course. It's human, isn't it?

HE: How do you come to know that?

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SHE: What?

HE: That it's-human? Agnes, I never heard you talk like this before. What's the matter with you?

SHE: Well, I might have my experience too, mightn't I *(Rises. Crossing onto dais, picks up clock from bed-table.)* Goodnight!

HE: *(Rises. Crossing to foot of bed.)* Just a minute! I want to hear a little more about this.

SHE: But I know it now, dear.

HE: Yes, you do! But I don't! What sort of experiences are you referring to?

SHE: *(Crossing to him. Puts clock on tabouret.)* Now listen, my little friend! You have dismissed me without notice, and I haven't complained once as any other housekeeper would have done. I have accepted the facts, because I know a human being is at the mercy of this feeling, however horrible and at the same time delicious it may be.

HE: *(At up Center.)* Agnes!

SHE: *(On dais.)* I really don't understand you. I am not thwarting you in the least, and instead of your going away happily and relieved that you are not going to leave a helpless wreck behind

HE: *(Crossing up to arch.)* You might answer just one plain question before we finish this business. Have you-aren't you going to be alone, if I leave you?

SHE: Alone? I've got the children, haven't I?

HE: *(Crossing down Center.)* That's not at all certain.

SHE: *(After a shaky silence.)* You had better leave this room very quickly now, before you get to know a side of me that might surprise you a lot.

HE: *(Crossing to her.)* I have, I'm afraid. I demand an answer. Have you a lover?

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SHE: *(Goes to door, opens it. Stands down Right of door.)* Good night.

HE: For eleven long years I have believed in you! *(Crossing to her.)* You were the purest, the noblest thing in my life!

SHE: *(Interrupting, and with him.)* -the noblest thing in my life! Good night!

HE: If you don't answer my question, you'll never see me again.

SHE: Get out of here.

HE: *(Sits on sofa at foot of bed.)* No.

SHE: All right. *(Crossing onto dais.)* Then there's only one thing left to be done. *(SHE picks up wrap from bed and crosses into dressing room Left.)*

HE: What? What did you want to say? *(She does not answer. SHE returns with second wrap and night case; puts them both on chair down Left and opens case.)* What's the meaning of that? *(SHE goes on, crosses onto dais, picks up nightgown and negligee. Crosses down Left, packs them in case.)* Darling, believe me, I won't blame you for anything, only tell me *(Rises, stands Left Center.)*-where are you going?

SHE: *(Crossing up Right to dressing table and getting brushes and comb.)* Would you mind calling a cab for me?

HE: *(Turning to her.)* Agnes!

SHE: *(Crossing down Left packs brushes and comb in case.)* Please, Michael, I can't arrive there too late. It is such an embarrassing time already. Pass me my alarm clock, will you?

HE: No, I can't have been mistaken about you that much! Only yesterday you said that I had qualities

SHE: Excuse me. *(Passes him, gets her alarm clock from the tabouret. Crosses down Left, puts clock in case.)*

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HE: *(Wants to stop her when she passes, but checks himself.)* All right. It is a solution, anyhow.

SHE: *(Closes overnight case, picks it up, puts wrap over arm, crosses Left around chair to him and puts out her hand. HE refuses. SHE starts Center below him. HE blocks her way.)* Goodbye, Michael.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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